

The Birth of the Patriarchy

up to 600CE

The role of women in prehistoric societies (before written records) is subject to debate, relying as it does on burial practices and excavated artefacts. However, evidence suggests that women played an important and active role in the prehistoric world. Pinpointing when patriarchies—in which men held all the power—began is a difficult task, but studies suggest that many ancient societies were early patriarchies. Ancient women faced a dichotomy: on the one hand, they could be revered as goddesses, mothers, objects of beauty, or the heads of households, yet on the other hand, they were rarely entitled to the same freedoms and rights as men.